

THE CAMARGUE

Europe's most famous coastal wetland

The largest river delta in Western Europe forms where the Rhône River splits to enclose more than 360 sq miles (930 sq km) of salt marsh, low-lying islands and sand bars, saltwater lagoons, and reed beds. In 1986, the Camargue was officially designated as a wetland of international importance. It is also a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Shifting landscape

The landforms of the Camargue shift continually, and the gradual accumulation of silt and sand means the delta is gradually growing. The coastal flats are stabilized by salt-tolerant sea lavender and glasswort. Further inland are juniper woodlands, and the north of the delta is stable enough to support agriculture including seasonal grazing for horses and cattle, rice paddies, and vineyards. Aside from the greater flamingos and semiwild horses for

which the region is famous, the most conspicuous wildlife of the Camargue in summer is often the mosquitoes—reputed to be the most voracious in France. These deeply unpopular bloodsucking insects are nevertheless an important food resource for birds such as house martins, swallows, and alpine swifts. Other insect life includes more than 30 species of dragonfly, but it is birds for which the wetlands are best known. More than 400 species live in or visit the Camargue, and egrets, herons, and harriers that would turn heads elsewhere are almost ubiquitous.



CAMARGUE CATTLE

FREE-RANGE CATTLE
The handsome black cattle that live semiwild in the Camargue are bred for beef and for bullfighting. They are ecologically important as grazers, controlling the growth of emergent wetland vegetation and maintaining areas of open water.

CRAYFISH PROBLEM

Since it was imported in the 1980s, the American red swamp crayfish has reduced the abundance and diversity of aquatic invertebrates and amphibians through competition, predation, and transmission of the frog-killing chytrid fungus.



RED SWAMP CRAYFISH

ESSENTIAL GRAZERS

Repeated outbreaks of myxomatosis have greatly reduced the number of rabbits in the Camargue. While grazing by cattle and horses continues, they are less efficient than rabbits at halting the encroachment of more vigorous shrubs.



EUROPEAN RABBIT

Parts protected as a Regional Natural Park since 1970 > 30-plus species of dragonfly

